

Bay Area real estate, answered.

32 questions Bay Area buyers and sellers actually ask, answered honestly.

Buyer's-agent fees · CalHFA · ADU red flags · the NAR settlement · and more.

You have questions. Here are 32 honest answers.

These are the questions Bay Area buyers and sellers actually ask me: about commissions, programs, escrow, ADUs, Prop 13, Mello-Roos, wildfire risk, and what a good agent should be doing for you.

Read the sections that apply to you.

The 32 questions in this guide are organized into nine categories. Costs & Commissions covers what the 2024 NAR settlement actually changed. Financing & Programs walks through CalHFA Dream for All, the Forgivable Equity Builder Loan, and what immigrant homebuyers should know. The Buying Process and The Selling Process cover the how-it-actually-works mechanics. Bay Area Specifics covers ADUs and inspection red flags. Bay Area Tax & Compliance covers Prop 13, Mello-Roos, the SB326 balcony law, and wildfire and flood disclosure. Special Transactions covers FSBOs, solar-panel ownership structures, Prop 19 inheritance reassessment, and the seller's house binder.

Trust & Ethics covers what an agent should be willing to do for you, including talk you out of a deal, and About & Contact tells you how to reach me when you're ready.

Most of what's in here is what I would tell you in person. The difference is that on the page, you can read it twice. Or hand it to your spouse. Or come back to it three months from now when the question becomes timely.

ABOUT ME, BRIEFLY

California licensed since 2016. In real estate since 2007. 102 closed transactions. \$111 million in cumulative sales volume.

Member, National Association of REALTORS®, California Association of REALTORS®, Silicon Valley Association of REALTORS®.

Cal DRE #02010731. Practicing through Centermac Realty, a multi-office California brokerage where the broker-of-record is also a licensed real-estate attorney.

Speaks English and Russian. Service area: 19 named cities across Silicon Valley, the East Bay, the Peninsula, San Francisco, and parts of Marin County.

COSTS & COMMISSIONS

2 QUESTIONS

How much does a buyer's agent cost in California?

In most Bay Area transactions, the buyer's agent is paid by the seller out of the sale proceeds at closing, so buyers typically pay no out-of-pocket commission. Following the 2024 NAR settlement, this is now formalized through a buyer-representation agreement signed before showings, which spells out exactly how the agent is compensated. Lily reviews this agreement plainly with every client before any home tour. In practice she treats it as a formality, not a binding leash: if the fit isn't right, you walk away, because the long-term relationship matters more than any single transaction.

What if I want to terminate my buyer's agent contract?

California buyer-representation agreements typically include termination provisions. Most agents will release a client who is unsatisfied: fighting over commission while still in the search phase is rare and usually ends badly for the agent's reputation. Lily's agreements are written for transparency: clear duration, clear scope, clear release terms.

FINANCING & PROGRAMS

5 QUESTIONS

What programs help first-time homebuyers in California?

California offers several first-time buyer assistance programs: California Forgivable Equity Builder Loan (up to 10% of purchase price, forgiven after 5 years), Dream for All (shared-appreciation loan), and CalHFA programs covering down payment and closing costs. Most have AMI thresholds and minimum credit-score requirements, so a free consultation is the first step.

What is the California Forgivable Equity Builder Loan?

The California Forgivable Equity Builder Loan provides first-time homebuyers with up to 10% of the home's purchase price toward down payment or closing costs. The loan is fully forgiven after 5 years of using the property as a primary residence. Eligibility: income below 80% of Area Median Income (~\$106,880 for the Bay Area), minimum 640 credit score.

What is the California Dream for All program and how do I apply?

California Dream for All is a CalHFA shared-appreciation loan that helps first-time buyers cover down payment and closing costs. The state contributes funds in exchange for a share of future appreciation when sold or refinanced. Application periods open in limited windows (most recent: February 24 to March 16, 2026) and funds typically run out within weeks. Lily helps buyers get pre-approved with a CalHFA-listed lender ahead of the next window.

Can I buy a home in California right after immigrating to the US?

Yes. Recent immigrants and visa holders (H-1B, L-1, O-1, EAD, green card in process) can buy a home in California. Most lenders prefer 2 years of US credit history for conventional loans, but ITIN and foreign-national programs exist for buyers without SSN or short credit history. Lily works with lenders specializing in immigrant transactions and helps build a path to purchase even before permanent-resident status.

Can I use my RSU stock grants to qualify for a Bay Area mortgage?

Most California lenders consider RSU (Restricted Stock Unit) income for mortgage qualifying with documented evidence: typically two years of vest history, a forward vest schedule signed by your employer, and a stock-price stability assessment. Lenders use a two-year average of vested RSU value, not the unvested forward schedule. ISO and NSO option income is treated more conservatively (often discounted 30-50% or excluded). Bay Area tech-buyer mechanics: time the offer to a vesting window, plan a 12-week pre-approval, and don't sell RSU shares before the lender confirms they aren't needed as documented assets. Mistimed sales have cost buyers their loans in escrow.

THE BUYING PROCESS

5 QUESTIONS

Is now a good time to buy a home in the Bay Area?

The 2025-2026 Bay Area market is a "split market": some neighborhoods see multiple offers above asking, others require price reductions. Buyers have meaningful negotiating leverage in segments they did not have for over a decade. Whether it's the right time depends on your finances, target neighborhood, and time horizon, not on a generic market call.

Should I wait for prices to drop?

The Bay Area's chronic inventory shortage and rigorous lending standards distinguish today's market from 2008. A meaningful price drop across the entire region requires either a recession or a wave of new construction, neither imminent. Specific neighborhoods may see corrections; others won't. The right answer depends on your scenario, not on a general market forecast.

What's the difference between a buyer's agent and a listing agent?

A buyer's agent represents the buyer and owes a fiduciary duty to advocate for the buyer's interests: negotiating price, reviewing disclosures, identifying risks. A listing agent represents the seller in reverse. The two should never be the same person in the same transaction (called "dual agency") unless the buyer fully understands the conflict.

How long does it take to close on a home in California?

A typical Bay Area home purchase closes in 21 to 30 days from accepted offer, with cash offers sometimes closing in as little as 7 to 14 days. Loan-financed purchases can extend to 30 to 45 days depending on the lender. Lily manages timelines tightly and coordinates with lenders, escrow, inspectors, and appraisers to keep contingencies on track.

Can Lily help me find off-market homes in the Bay Area?

Yes. Lily maintains a curated off-market network through Centermac Realty and her broker relationships across the Bay Area, surfacing homes before they hit MLS, Coming Soon, Pocket Listings, and Off-Market opportunities. Subscribe at lilygaripova.com/off-market/ (English) or [/ru/off-market/](https://ru.off-market/) (Russian).

THE SELLING PROCESS

3 QUESTIONS

How should I price my home in the Bay Area in 2026?

In the 2025-2026 split market, pricing strategy depends on neighborhood-specific comps, days-on-market trends, school district, condition, and current competition. Lily practices the Strategic Listing Model: data-driven pricing with managed competitive bidding rather than overpriced listings that sit. Example: her Springer Way listing in San Jose was priced at \$1,588,000 and sold for \$1,800,000, a \$212,000 premium.

What does Lily do as a listing agent?

As a listing agent, Lily executes a three-phase Strategic Listing Model: (1) data-driven pricing with comparable analysis and competitive mapping; (2) home preparation including pre-listing improvements with positive ROI, professional staging, and photography; (3) multi-platform marketing with active bid management to extract maximum buyer competition.

How long does it take to sell a Bay Area home?

Total time from listing decision to close typically runs 45 to 60 days: roughly 1 to 2 weeks for prep, 1 to 4 weeks active on market (the first 7 to 14 days drive most offers), and 21 to 30 days in escrow after offer acceptance.

BAY AREA SPECIFICS

3 QUESTIONS

What are common home inspection red flags in Bay Area homes?

Common Bay Area inspection red flags vary by housing era: pre-1978 homes may have lead paint and asbestos; 1990s-era plumbing may use defective CPVC; older homes often need foundation/seismic retrofits; ADUs and bonus rooms are frequently unpermitted (Lily recently saved a Campbell buyer \$100K when due-diligence revealed an unpermitted ADU).

What is an ADU and does it add value to a home?

An ADU (Accessory Dwelling Unit) is a secondary living unit on a residential property, often a converted garage, basement, or detached structure with a kitchen, bathroom, and bedroom. Permitted ADUs add legal living square footage and can generate rental income; unpermitted ADUs can be a six-figure liability if discovered after purchase. California's 2025 ADU grandfathering rules made legalization easier but still costly.

How do I know if the listing agent is hiding something?

The listing agent isn't lying when they pass along seller statements: that's their job. Verifying whether what the seller said is actually true is not their job. If you're buying, this work falls on your side or it doesn't get done. Recent example: Lily was on a \$2.5M Campbell deal where the listing agent confirmed the ADU was "permitted." A 5-minute call to the City of Campbell revealed it wasn't. The next day a city inspector red-tagged the property, saving Lily's buyer \$100K in renegotiation.

BAY AREA TAX & COMPLIANCE

4 QUESTIONS

How does California's Proposition 13 affect my Bay Area home purchase?

Proposition 13 caps annual increases in your property's assessed value at 2% per year, regardless of market appreciation. Practical effect: a \$1.5M Bay Area purchase today gets reassessed at full price, while the previous owner who bought in the 1990s paid taxes on an assessment far below current market value. Your initial property tax bill runs roughly 1.25% of the purchase price (about \$18,750/year on \$1.5M), plus Mello-Roos and special assessments where applicable. Inheriting a Prop-13-protected home transfers some of that benefit under Prop 19, but with significant new restrictions since 2021.

What is Mello-Roos and which Bay Area neighborhoods have it?

Mello-Roos is a special property-tax district layered on top of the standard 1.25% property tax to fund infrastructure (roads, schools, parks) in new-construction tracts. It can add \$5,000 to \$15,000+ per year. Active Bay Area locations: new tracts in Dublin (Boulevard), San Ramon (Windemere, Gale Ranch), Tracy, Mountain House, and Brentwood new-construction subdivisions. Bonds typically run 25 to 40 years from issuance. Always pull the preliminary title report and check for Mello-Roos line items before writing an offer; most buyers discover them too late.

What is California's SB326 balcony law and how does it affect condo and townhome buyers?

SB326 (the California Balcony Inspection Law, effective 2019, first inspections due January 2025, remediation by 2029) requires every multi-family residential building with elevated wood-framed balconies, decks, and walking surfaces to undergo a structural inspection by a licensed engineer or architect every nine years. Bay Area HOAs are levying special assessments of \$5,000 to \$30,000+ per unit to comply. Before buying any condo or townhome, demand the SB326 inspection report and the HOA's compliance status, and read recent meeting minutes for pending special-assessment votes.

How can I check a Bay Area home's wildfire and flood risk before making an offer?

Pull three independent sources before writing an offer: (1) CAL FIRE's Fire Hazard Severity Zone map (returns Very High, High, Moderate, or Low classification by address); (2) FEMA's flood-zone map (returns Zone A, AE, X, and similar designations); (3) AB-38 defensible-space requirements if the property is in a state-defined Wildland-Urban Interface. California Realtors successfully lobbied to remove wildfire and flood data from Zillow and Redfin in 2024, so most buyers no longer see these signals on listing pages. Lily pulls them for every property before her clients write an offer.

SPECIAL TRANSACTIONS

4 QUESTIONS

What should I know before buying or selling a Bay Area FSBO?

California FSBO (For Sale By Owner) transactions skip the listing agent but still require strict adherence to state disclosure law: complete Transfer Disclosure Statement, Natural Hazard Disclosure, lead-based paint disclosure for pre-1978 homes, Megan's Law notice, and water-heater, smoke-alarm, and CO-detector compliance. Three gotchas that derail California FSBOs: (1) verbal modification of fully-executed contracts; (2) unsigned counter-offers without proper paperwork trail; (3) missing required statutory disclosures. If you have an active buyer-rep agreement and want to pursue a FSBO, the agreement's exit clause should address how representation works for an off-MLS property.

How do I evaluate a Bay Area home with existing solar panels?

Solar panels come with one of four very different ownership structures: (1) *Owned outright* panels transfer free at close. (2) *Leased* you inherit a 20-year contract you can't easily cancel; the lender may require subordination or payoff. (3) *PPA (Power Purchase Agreement)* you buy electricity from the panels at a fixed rate; contracts typically run 20+ years. (4) *PACE (Property Assessed Clean Energy)* financing attached to the property tax bill as a senior lien; many conventional lenders won't fund a purchase with active PACE unless paid off at close. Pull the preliminary title report: the panel-ownership structure shows up in disclosures or as a lien.

How does Proposition 19 affect inheriting a Bay Area home?

Prop 19 (effective February 2021) significantly tightened the rules for inheriting property with low Prop-13-protected assessed value. Before Prop 19, a child could inherit a parent's home at the parent's old assessed value. After Prop 19, the inherited home keeps the low assessed value only if the child uses it as a primary residence AND the family-home exclusion applies; even then, the portion of market value above the old assessed value plus \$1M is partially reassessed. Rent out or sell an inherited home within a few years and you trigger reassessment at full market value, often \$10,000 to \$30,000+ added to the annual tax bill. Centermac Realty's broker-of-record is also a licensed real estate attorney; estate-context transactions go to him first.

What documents should I assemble before listing my Bay Area home?

A complete house binder measurably moves the offer-price needle and reduces transaction friction. Bay Area sellers should compile: (1) original purchase paperwork plus the title report; (2) all permits ever pulled from the city building department; (3) major-renovation receipts, warranties, and contractor contacts; (4) seismic-retrofit certifications if applicable; (5) recent appliance manuals and service records; (6) roof and HVAC service history; (7) tree-service and arborist records (Oakland has levied six-figure fines for unpermitted tree removal); (8) HOA documents if applicable; (9) solar-panel ownership paperwork; (10) any pending insurance claims. A complete binder signals organized ownership, supports the listing-strategy pricing, and answers buyer due-diligence questions before they become contract contingencies.

TRUST & ETHICS

3 QUESTIONS

Will Lily talk me out of buying a home if she finds problems?

Yes. Lily practices what her clients call the "Ethics of No": she will recommend walking away from a property when inspections, disclosures, or contract terms reveal risks that compromise long-term financial security. This is documented across her Zillow reviews as one of the most-cited reasons clients trust her. Result: more transactions take longer, but very few become regrets.

Does Lily Garipova speak Russian?

Yes. Russian is Lily's native language and English is fluent. She represents Russian-speaking buyers, sellers, and investors across the Bay Area with all paperwork, negotiation, and inspection review available in either language. Russian-language website: lilygaripova.com/ru.

Why would I want a Russian-speaking agent if I speak English fine?

Real estate documents are dense, 100 to 300+ pages per transaction, and the technical vocabulary doesn't translate cleanly. An agent who works in Russian at the document-review level can explain financial and legal implications in your native language while still negotiating fluently with the English-speaking other side. The difference between "translates at showings" and "works in Russian and English at every step" is the difference between feeling lost and feeling protected.

ABOUT LILY & CONTACT

3 QUESTIONS

I'm relocating to the Bay Area: can Lily help me find a home remotely?

Yes. Lily works regularly with clients relocating from out of state and abroad, including from New York, the Pacific Northwest, Texas, Southern California, and internationally. She offers virtual tours, FaceTime walkthroughs, neighborhood comparisons, and remote document execution. Russian-speaking clients relocating from CIS countries get full support in Russian and English.

What areas does Lily Garipova serve?

The entire San Francisco Bay Area: East Bay (Oakland, Fremont, Hayward, Castro Valley, Union City), Contra Costa (Concord, Walnut Creek, Danville, San Ramon, Pleasanton, Martinez), South Bay (San Jose, Santa Clara, Sunnyvale, Cupertino, Mountain View, Milpitas, Campbell), Silicon Valley (Palo Alto, Los Altos, Menlo Park, Atherton, Redwood City), Peninsula (Saratoga, Los Gatos), San Francisco, Pacifica, and Marin County.

What is Lily Garipova's phone number?

Phone: 415-910-3958. Email: lilyagaripova@gmail.com. Cal DRE# 02010731. Available evenings and weekends for showings.

Have a question that isn't here? Let's talk.

The first conversation is free, has no commitment, and Lily will tell you honestly whether now is the right time to move forward.

Three ways to reach me.

CALL OR TEXT

(415) 910-3958

Available evenings and weekends for questions, consultations, and showings. Same-day reply.

EMAIL

lilyagaripova@gmail.com

ONLINE

lilygaripova.com, main site (English)

lilygaripova.com/ru, Russian-language site

lilygaripova.com/faq, full FAQ with all 32 questions

lilygaripova.com/off-market, off-market listings

WHEN TO CALL NOW VS. LATER

Now if: a CalHFA window is open, you found a home you want to write on, your inspection turned up something concerning, or your timeline is under 60 days. Otherwise: a free pre-search consultation 3 to 6 months before you'd ideally close is usually the right rhythm.

Lily Garipova

CENTERMAC REALTY

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English & Russian

Next step: if you found this useful, the most valuable thing you can do is share it with someone else who's about to buy or sell. Most of Lily's clients arrive by referral.

If you're the one buying or selling, call.